

BEFORE YOU RIDE

NATCHEZ TRACE PARKWAY

LOWER TRACE SELF-GUIDED CYCLING TOUR

~82 MILES	BEGINNER	ROAD/HYBRID	SPRING / FALL	MODERATE	BNB
DISTANCE	DIFFICULTY	BIKE TYPE	BEST SEASONS	PACE	LODGING STYLE

ESSENTIAL INFORMATION

START POINT **NATCHEZ VISITOR CENTER, NATCHEZ, MS (MILEPOST 0)**

END POINT **ROCKY SPRINGS CAMPSITE, MS (MILEPOST 54.8)**

RESUPPLY **NATCHEZ (START), PORT GIBSON (MP 39.2) — STOCK UP, LIMITED OPTIONS BETWEEN**

CASH **BRING CASH — MANY SMALL TOWNS AND LOCAL RESTAURANTS ARE CASH ONLY**

CELL SERVICE **SPOTTY IN MANY SECTIONS — DOWNLOAD OFFLINE MAPS BEFORE DEPARTING**

TRAFFIC **NO TRUCKS OR COMMERCIAL VEHICLES EVER PERMITTED ON THE PARKWAY**

WATER **AVAILABLE AT NPS VISITOR CENTERS AND CAMPGROUNDS — CARRY 2L MINIMUM**

EMERGENCY **NPS RANGER STATION: (601) 446-6672 · CALL 911 FOR EMERGENCIES**

GETTING THERE & BACK

DRIVING

Leave your car at the Natchez Visitor Center (free, secure NPS lot). Arrange a return shuttle to pick you up at Rocky Springs on your final day, or have someone drive your car to meet you.

FLYING

Fly into Jackson–Evers International Airport (JAN), ~90 min from Natchez. Downtown Karla Brown offers bike-friendly shuttle service from Jackson airport to Natchez — approximately \$45/person including your bike. Book in advance: find her via [NatchezTraceTravel.com](#)

BIKE SHIPPING

BikeFlights.com ships your bike to your hotel and back home. Starts around \$60 each way. Book 1–2 weeks ahead.

EBIKE NOTE

E-bike riders: confirm charging availability when booking lodging. All recommended B&Bs below can accommodate e-bike charging. Rocky Springs NPS campsite has no power — plan battery accordingly.

SEASONAL RIDING CONDITIONS

SPRING

March–May is peak season. Wildflowers are spectacular. Book B&Bs 6+ weeks ahead. Insects emerge in April — pack repellent. Mornings can be cool (40s°F), afternoons warm (70s°F). Best overall window: mid-March to early May.

SUMMER

June–August is hot and humid (90s°F+). Only recommended for early morning starts. Be on the road by 7am and off by noon. Carry extra water. Not recommended for first-timers.

FALL

September–November brings cooler temps and fall color. October is the sweet spot. Fewer crowds than spring. B&Bs more available but still book ahead for weekends. Daylight shorter — plan to finish riding by 5:30pm in November.

WINTER

December–February is quiet and mild by northern standards (40–60°F), but some B&Bs and restaurants have reduced hours. Call ahead. Can be beautiful and uncrowded.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

PDF GUIDE

Read each day page the night before. Review lodging and dining while you have WiFi.

GPX FILE

Load into Garmin, Wahoo, Komoot, or RideWithGPS before you leave home. Download offline maps.

CUE SHEET

Print and laminate for your map case or jersey pocket. Essential when cell service drops.



01

DAY 1 OF 3

ARRIVAL & NATCHEZ EXPLORATION

ARRIVAL
DISTANCE

NATCHEZ
OVERNIGHT

Arrive in Natchez — one of the oldest cities on the Mississippi River. Spend the afternoon and evening exploring before your ride begins tomorrow.

HISTORY & CONTEXT

Natchez sits on a bluff 200 feet above the Mississippi River and has been continuously inhabited for over 10,000 years. The Natchez people maintained their capital here until colonial wars in the 1730s dispersed them. By the early 1800s, Natchez had become the wealthiest city per capita in the United States — built on cotton and enslaved labor. The antebellum mansions you see today are the legacy of that era. The city was largely spared during the Civil War, preserving much of its extraordinary 19th century architecture intact.

POINTS OF INTEREST



NATCHEZ BLUFFS

Stunning Mississippi River overlooks. Best at sunset.

WALK



ANTEBELLUM MANSIONS

Stanton Hall, Longwood, Dunleith — book tours ahead in spring.

TOUR



DOWNTOWN NATCHEZ

Historic Main Street, local restaurants, shops.

EXPLORE



OVERNIGHT: NATCHEZ

See lodging recommendations below.

DAY 1 — OVERNIGHT

NATCHEZ

Dinner Note: Natchez has the best dining on the route. Magnolia Grill for a river-view first night, or Frankie's on Main for something special.

LODGING: NATCHEZ

★ **THE BURN LUXURY INN**

\$150–200/night

Stunning antebellum property, full breakfast included, pool and gardens. Nell is an exceptional host.

Booking.com or direct

★ **SUNNYSIDE B&B**

\$125–175/night

Intimate, owner Colleen is fascinating — expect a 3-hour breakfast conversation about the home's history.

Direct: (601) 807-1148

RIVERBOAT B&B

\$125–150/night

Bikes welcome, great central location, homemade breakfast with farm-fresh eggs.

Direct: (601) 445-8217

NATCHEZ GRAND HOTEL

\$100–150/night

Convenient downtown location, river views from some rooms. Rooms are aging — manage expectations.

Booking.com

DINING TONIGHT

Magnolia Grill

SEAFOOD / SOUTHERN \$\$

Shrimp & grits, river view, right Under-the-Hill. The obvious first-night pick. 4.5★ / 1,700 reviews.

Tue–Sun 11am–9/10pm, closed Mon

Frankie's on Main

AMERICAN / UPSCALE \$\$\$

Renovated bank building, excellent food, great atmosphere. Best for a celebratory first night. 4.6★

Tue–Sat 11am–10pm, closed Sun–Mon

The Camp

CASUAL / AMERICAN \$\$

Also Under-the-Hill, river views, more casual. Catfish, burgers, great atmosphere. 4.5★

Daily 11am–8/9pm

BREAKFAST TOMORROW

Natchez Coffee Co

CAFE / BREAKFAST \$

Opens 6am. Very popular with locals. Perfect pre-ride fuel. 4.3★ / 800+ reviews.

Mon–Sat 6am–5pm, Sun 6am–2pm

The Little Easy

BRUNCH CAFE \$\$

Chicken & waffles, mimosas, charming atmosphere. Great if you have a relaxed morning. 4.3★

Daily 8am–2pm (Fri also 6–9pm)



Your first day of riding begins at the Natchez Visitor Center. The Parkway wraps you in forest and calm immediately. Keep eyes open for deer, wild turkey, and armadillos in the early miles. Smooth NPS pavement, light car traffic, and your pace entirely your own.

HISTORY & CONTEXT

This is the most historically dense day on the route. Emerald Mound at mile 10 is one of the most significant pre-Columbian sites in the country — a ceremonial platform mound covering eight acres, built by the Plaquemine culture between 1300–1600 CE. Further north, Mount Locust was the first inn on the Trace, serving the boatmen walking home to Nashville after floating goods to New Orleans. The Sunken Trace near mile 25 shows the physical depth of the route's history — the trail worn six to eight feet below grade by centuries of foot and hoof traffic.

TERRAIN

~42 MILES · ROLLING HILLS · SMOOTH NPS ASPHALT ALL DAY

A longer day but consistent terrain — smooth NPS asphalt with a 3–5ft paved shoulder throughout. Gentle rolling hills through dense hardwood forest. No significant climbs. The biggest elevation is gradual and spread over miles. Moderate pace riders typically complete this in 3.5–5 hours of riding time.

POINTS OF INTEREST

MP	STOP	DETAILS

LUNCH OPTIONS

DAY 2 — OVERNIGHT

PORT GIBSON

Dinner Note: Port Gibson: limited options but the Isabella or Collina hosts always know what’s good and open. The 61 Fish Market closes at 7pm — worth it for the catfish.

LODGING: PORT GIBSON

★ **ISABELLA BED & BREAKFAST**

\$100–150/night

Cyclist-specific reviews praise this place — locked bike storage, cold drinks waiting on arrival, expert local tips. 4.9★

Direct: (601) 437-5097

COLLINA HOUSE

\$100–150/night

Gorgeous 1800s plantation property, very welcoming hosts Scott and Katy, full breakfast. 5.0★

Direct: (504) 481-3166

DINING TONIGHT

Ask your B&B host

LOCAL RECOMMENDATION **VARIES**

Port Gibson dining options change frequently. Both Isabella and Collina hosts are excellent at current restaurant recommendations. The town is small — trust local knowledge.

61 Fish Market

SEAFOOD \$

Fresh fried catfish, open until 7pm. Good early dinner option if you arrive before 6:30pm. 4.5★

Daily 9am–7pm (Sun noon–6pm)

BREAKFAST TOMORROW

Your B&B hosts

FULL SOUTHERN BREAKFAST **INCLUDED**

Both Isabella and Collina serve full Southern breakfasts. This is genuinely the best meal option in town — take your time and fuel up for the day.

By arrangement

Mississippi's Finest

SOUL FOOD \$

Opens at 11am — good lunch stop rather than breakfast. Fried chicken and rice & gravy are exceptional. 4.7★

Mon–Sat 11am–3pm, closed Sun



Today features the single most memorable detour on the Lower Trace — the Windsor Ruins. Plan extra time. The day ends at Rocky Springs, a ghost town slowly reclaimed by forest, where the free NPS campsite sits among ruins of what was once a community of 2,600 people.

HISTORY & CONTEXT

Windsor Ruins and Rocky Springs tell two very different stories about the antebellum South's rise and fall. Windsor was the grandest mansion in Mississippi, built in 1861 and surviving the Civil War only to burn in 1890 from a dropped cigarette — 23 cast-iron columns are all that remain. Rocky Springs, by contrast, was a community of ordinary people whose town was slowly erased by yellow fever, war, soil exhaustion, and the boll weevil. The 1837 Methodist Church still stands among the ruins, holding services until 1904. Both sites sit quietly in the forest now, reclaimed by the same landscape that once fed them.

TERRAIN

~40 MILES · ROLLING HILLS · NPS ASPHALT + WINDSOR RUINS DETOUR ON COUNTY ROAD

Your longest day. Smooth NPS asphalt throughout, with one notable exception: the Windsor Ruins detour onto Rodney Road is a narrow 2-lane county road with no shoulder. Ride single file, stay right. The detour is 1.5 miles each way on rougher pavement. The final approach to Rocky Springs includes a 0.3-mile gravel access road to the campsite — walk it if you're on 25mm road tires.

POINTS OF INTEREST

MP	STOP	DETAILS

LUNCH OPTIONS

DAY 3 — OVERNIGHT

ROCKY SPRINGS

Dinner Note: ⚠ No food at Rocky Springs. Carry dinner and tomorrow's breakfast from Port Gibson. Non-negotiable.

LODGING: ROCKY SPRINGS

★ **ROCKY SPRINGS NPS CAMPGROUND**

Free

First come, first served. Water spigot on site. Bear boxes provided. The 1837 Methodist Church and ghost town ruins are a short walk away.

No reservation needed

WHAT TO PACK

ALL RIDERS

- Navigation: Offline maps downloaded (Google Maps or Gaia GPS), this cue sheet (Garmin or Wahoo GPS with GPX loaded)
- Safety: Front and rear lights, helmet, ID, emergency contacts, basic first aid (Personal locator beacon for remote sections)
- Clothing: Padded shorts, jersey x2, lightweight rain jacket, arm warmers (Chamois cream, sun sleeves for hot days)
- Other: Cash \$50+ minimum, sunscreen, insect repellent (essential spring) (Small padlock for bike at overnight stops)

INN TO INN RIDERS

- Bike: Road or hybrid bike, spare tubes x2, pump, multi-tool, chain lube (Handlebar bag or small frame bag)
- Food & Water: 2x bottles minimum, snacks for the day — meals at restaurants nightly (Electrolyte tabs for hot days)
- Luggage: Small backpack or handlebar bag — B&Bs carry your overnight essentials (Lightweight dry bag for rain protection)

NAVIGATION OPTIONS

GPX FILE

Import to Garmin, Wahoo, Komoot, Ride with GPS, or Apple Maps

Included in your download from [openride.bike](#)

RIDE WITH GPS

View interactive map, turn cues on your phone, export GPX

[ridewithgps.com](#) — [search OpenRide Natchez Trace](#)

GOOGLE MAPS OFFLINE

Download the region over WiFi before your trip

[Open Google Maps](#) → [find area](#) → [tap Download](#)

NPS PARKWAY MAP

Official map with all mileposts, facilities, campgrounds marked

[nps.gov/natr](#) — [free PDF download](#)

KOMOOT

Excellent cycling-specific routing and navigation app

[komoot.com](#) — [search Natchez Trace](#)

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NATCHEZ TRACE PARKWAY

This route guide was curated by a professional bicycle tour guide with over 10 years of experience leading tours on the Natchez Trace Parkway. Every stop, every note, and every recommendation comes from real miles ridden on this road.

YOUR ROUTE · YOUR PACE · YOUR ADVENTURE

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